

HORIZON-WIDERA-2023-ERA-01-06: Building a virtual European Info Platform on Contemporary China

Specific conditions	
<i>Expected EU contribution per</i>	The Commission estimates that an EU contribution of around EUR 2.50 million would allow these outcomes to be addressed appropriately. Nonetheless, this does not preclude submission and selection of a

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Widening participation and strengthening the European Research Area

<i>project</i>	proposal requesting different amounts.
<i>Indicative budget</i>	The total indicative budget for the topic is EUR 2.50 million.
<i>Type of Action</i>	Coordination and Support Actions

Expected Outcome: The action funded under this topic will have the objective of networking excellent knowledge nodes supporting the advancement of independent knowledge on contemporary China from across the European Union to build a virtual European Info Platform on contemporary China that will become sustainable beyond the end of the project. The goal of the platform would be to collect, connect, produce, select, disseminate, and give visibility to excellent knowledge on Contemporary China produced in the European Union (e.g., by universities, think tanks, research centres, NGOs, private companies, public organisations etc.) so as to foster the development of a network of independent knowledge on contemporary China at European level, raise awareness, and mainstream information on China also within the wider remit of civil society. The virtual European Info Platform will aim to become a key go-to source for independent knowledge on contemporary China at European level across all major relevant research areas (foreign policy, domestic politics, contemporary society and culture, science, technology, and innovation policy, economics, law, etc.). This action supports ERA Policy Agenda action 9 on promoting international cooperation.

Projects are expected to contribute to the following outcomes:

- Bring together knowledge nodes on contemporary China from across Europe to build and manage a virtual European Info Platform on contemporary China that would become a European key go-to source of independent knowledge on contemporary China;
- Coordinate with other initiatives and stakeholders where relevant for the action. Synergies with the two projects that were selected for funding under the previous call ‘HORIZON-CL2-2021-TRANSFORMATIONS-01-07: Upgrading Independent Knowledge on Contemporary China in Europe’ are strongly encouraged. The work they bring forth should contribute to the development of the European Info Platform on Contemporary China;
- Regularly upload and disseminate knowledge on contemporary China, (including analyses, reports, articles, policy briefs, scoping studies, interviews, podcasts, etc.), not only produced by the successful consortium, but also filtered/selected from the work of external prominent and emerging knowledge nodes on contemporary China from across Europe, so as to give visibility to all relevant European centres of excellence (including the smaller ones);
- Successful proposals would be expected to build into the website a section dedicated to the translation into English of key Chinese policy-documents and to create related policy briefs that would be openly accessible;

- Organise the material to be uploaded on the platform into thematic sections taking into account the priorities identified through the interactions with the relevant experts. A section of the platform should be specifically dedicated to understanding China's STI (science, technology, and innovation) system/policy and its implications for the European Union;
- Organise virtual and physical events (conferences, workshops, networking activities, trainings, staff exchanges, etc.), and manage their related communication activities, to foster pan-European connections among the different EU knowledge nodes on contemporary China. The organisation of China-focused thematic courses, ad-hoc seminars, and trainings, is encouraged in order to raise awareness on key China-related subjects, also involving the wider civil society/public/private institutions beyond China experts;
- Provide the Commission with regular policy recommendations and updates on the activities of the project;
- Reach out and encourage the participation of excellent knowledge centres from Eastern European Member States producing independent knowledge on contemporary China to enhance the visibility and impact of their work and foster the cross-fertilisation of knowledge;
- Prepare and put in place a sustainability plan for the platform to ensure the continuation of the work after the end of the action.

Scope: This topic contributes to the priority areas of action number 9 on *promoting a positive environment and level playing field for international cooperation based on reciprocity* listed in the Council Conclusions on the Future Governance of the European Research Area⁵⁶ (ERA). More specifically it aims to satisfy the objective of *launching a pilot initiative on the Team Europe approach for a specific world region and/or topic*.

This action seeks to bolster a stronger European understanding of contemporary China and to strengthen European's capacity to sustain the production of such knowledge that is key to develop excellent EU-China policy-making based on facts, independent and unbiased analyses, and foresight. In accordance with the EU-China – A Strategic Outlook Communication of 2019⁵⁷ and the Global Approach to Research and Innovation Communication of May 2021⁵⁸, the action aims to empower the European Union to act coherently and proactively on the international stage preserving an open research and innovation ecosystem while safeguarding European interests and values.

Today China is a key global actor and a leading scientific and technological power. China's increasing relevance in the geopolitical system has exposed the weakness the European Union

⁵⁶ <https://data.consilium.europa.eu/doc/document/ST-14126-2021-INIT/en/pdf>

⁵⁷ <https://ec.europa.eu/info/sites/default/files/communication-eu-china-a-strategic-outlook.pdf>

⁵⁸ https://ec.europa.eu/info/sites/default/files/research_and_innovation/strategy_on_research_and_innovation/documents/ec_rtd_com2021-252.pdf

faces in its capacity to better understand contemporary China in its various specificities, complexities, and goals and respond to its rapid evolution and new policy directions. The European Union needs to get to know and understand it on its own terms: not through the lens of other external sources but from its own European perspective. The underlined priority for the EU to develop its own knowledge capacity to navigate China's continuous transformations is embedded in the concept of independent European knowledge, which should guide the work of successful applicants.

Following interactions with Member States, China experts, and stakeholders in the framework of the EU R&I Knowledge Network on China (EUKNOC) and following the publication of the SFIC recommendations on China in November 2021⁵⁹ it has emerged that at the European level expertise on contemporary China is often fragmented and difficult to access. Networking existing prominent and emerging knowledge nodes, gathering, categorising, and mainstreaming their work on an easily accessible public information platform would be therefore pivotal to break siloes and provide policy-makers, researchers, businesses, and civil society with the tools needed to develop a deeper understanding of the different dimensions that characterise contemporary China. Doing so would also increase the circulation of information and foster the creation of new knowledge, in line with the Commission's efforts to upgrade independent knowledge on contemporary China in Europe started in the 2021-2022 Horizon Europe work programme⁶⁰. Building synergies with granted projects from topic HORIZON-CL2-2021-TRANSFORMATIONS-01-07, would be therefore strongly encouraged.

This action should bring forth the creation of a virtual European Info Platform on Contemporary China through networking relevant knowledge nodes from across the European Union that pursue the advancement of independent knowledge on contemporary China. The platform would collect, connect, produce, select, disseminate, and give visibility to excellent research material and provide translations from Chinese into English of relevant Chinese policy documents (and produce subsequent policy briefs on such documents). The successful consortium will be in charge of setting up the platform, organising/curating the material on the new virtual tool, setting up relevant events, thematic courses and trainings, communication activities, and developing a sustainability plan to ensure the successful continuation and growth of the platform after the end of the action.

The involvement of excellent knowledge centres from Eastern European Member States producing independent knowledge on contemporary China is strongly encouraged to foster the cross-fertilisation of knowledge on contemporary China across the European Union and enhance the visibility of their work.

⁵⁹ <https://data.consilium.europa.eu/doc/document/ST-1204-2021-INIT/en/pdf>

NB - Such recommendations call, among others, for the EU to build a permanent EU Info Centre for policy, academic, media and business based on existing networks and expertise available on China and to establish links between stakeholders from academia, public and private sector to create a network of China related actors and work on China in a concerted way.

⁶⁰ <https://ec.europa.eu/info/funding-tenders/opportunities/portal/screen/opportunities/topic-details/horizon-cl2-2021-transformations-01-07> -